

Storing Incoming Invoices

Database recommendation - Automated Invoice Capture

This note sets out our recommendation for where incoming supplier invoices should be stored, and the reasoning behind it. Two facts about your setup shape the answer:

- **Volume and users.** Up to around 1,000 invoices per day, with at most two people verifying them at any one time.
- **Marathon is the destination.** The approved, coded invoice is delivered into Marathon, which remains the system of record.

The key point

Because the approved invoice lives in Marathon - with Marathon's approval chain, purchase ledger and long-term retention - the capture system's own database does not need to be a permanent archive. It is a working store: it holds each invoice while it is read and verified, delivers it to Marathon, and keeps a small amount of data to catch duplicates and to read each supplier's layout better over time. The obligations of immutable, long-term, audited storage sit with Marathon, not with us.

Our recommendation: SQLite

We recommend SQLite - a small, proven database that runs inside the application itself, with no separate database server to install, run, secure or back up. For a focused internal tool of this size it is the simplest option that fully does the job.

- **Comfortably within its limits.** Around 1,000 invoices a day is a small fraction of what SQLite handles.
- **Two users is no concern.** It easily supports the few people and background tasks involved.
- **Fewer moving parts.** No database server means less to maintain, less to go wrong, and lower running cost.
- **Trivial backup.** The whole database is a single file that can be copied or continuously mirrored offsite.
- **Search built in.** Full-text search across invoice contents, with no extra software.

What we store, and for how long

Because Marathon holds the permanent record, the capture database stays small. Once an invoice has been safely delivered to Marathon we keep it for a short reference period - for example 30 to 90 days - and then remove the invoice content, retaining only a small fingerprint (so the same invoice can never be paid twice) and the learning data that makes future invoices faster to process.

One practical requirement

SQLite runs on the application server's own local disk, not on a shared network drive. This is a standard requirement and simply guides where the software is installed.

A considered choice, not a limitation

For large, multi-server systems the industry-standard database is PostgreSQL. We have kept the design so that moving to PostgreSQL later - should volumes or the number of users grow substantially - is a straightforward migration rather than a rewrite. Choosing SQLite now therefore commits you to nothing.

	SQLite (recommended)	PostgreSQL
Setup & operation	Runs inside the app; nothing to run	Separate server to run & secure
Best suited to	Focused tool, a few users	Many users / multiple servers
Backup	Copy a single file	Managed backups
For this project	Ideal fit	More than needed today

In short: SQLite gives you a simpler, lower-maintenance system that fully meets today's needs, with a clear path to PostgreSQL preserved should you ever need it.